THE OPENING — LEAD GM SCRIPT (ABOUT 5 MIN)

BEFORE YOU START

- Pairs seated together, with their character sheets.
- **Grand Gate board** in the middle, all 5 sockets empty. **Suspect Board** face down.
- Helpers at their stations, envelopes ready, stations covered.
- Lights low. Thunder or organ sound cued (optional).
- **Secret:** the ghost is **Anton the Apprentice** in costume. Three hints are marked ★ below. Say each once, casually, and never point them out.

1 · THE INVITATION (READ ALOUD, ABOUT 1 MIN)

> Every year on Halloween night, the Von Zarovich Estate throws open its doors for the Masquerade of the Five Crests. The legend says the old Count hid his fortune behind the Grand Gate, and the Gate opens only for whoever brings back all five of his Crests from the five rooms of the castle. Nobody has managed it in a hundred years.
>
> This year, the strangest guest list in history has climbed the hill through the fog: a vampire, a werewolf dad, a mummy, a very large and very nervous Frankenstein, an invisible man, a backpacker, a chef with a rat, and a van full of meddling kids and their dog.
>
> The doors close behind you with a BOOM. Candles gutter. In the centre of the great hall stands the Grand Gate: black iron, five empty sockets in a ring, and a lock shaped like a snarling wolf.

Tap the Gate board.

MEET THE ESTATE STAFF (READ ALOUD BEFORE THE PHANTOM, 60-90 SECONDS)

DM coaching: These are the three staff members, not yet announced as suspects. Say each name clearly. Give all three equal attention and allow one quick player response apiece. Keep the trait-comparison board hidden until the return to the Gate. Use these beats within the opening's five-minute budget by shortening the invitation and ghost performance; extended conversation is optional. Do not emphasize Anton's evidence traits or play him as obviously guilty.

Anton, the Alchemist's Apprentice

Voice: brisk, a little defensive; straighten an imaginary coat.

> A young man with an ink-stained guest list hurries over. "Anton. Alchemist's apprentice. Welcome to the Estate. Please don't drink anything just because it's glowing. Apparently we have to say that now."
> He looks over your group. "A vampire, a mummy, and a talking dog. Right. I'll put you down as 'family gathering.' Can I take a bag?"

If asked about his master: "We had a professional disagreement. He said I needed more practice. I said he needed a holiday." Then move to Tobias; do not explain the firing yet.

Master Tobias, the Clockmaker

Voice: clipped and fussy; listen to an imaginary pocket watch.

> Beside the great clock, a small man with snowy hair raises one finger. "Master Tobias. Clockmaker. You're forty-three seconds late. Or my clock is forty-three seconds fast. Obviously, it's the first one."
> He snaps his watch shut. "Enjoy the masquerade. Touch nothing that ticks. If it starts ticking after you touch it, come and find me. Walking, please."

If asked about the castle: "A beautiful collection of mechanisms, maintained by a staff with no respect for schedules." Give Anton and Grisela the same brief, irritated glance.

Grisela, the Groundskeeper

Voice: low, dry, unimpressed; scrape an imaginary muddy boot.

> A towering woman props a muddy spade beside the door. "Grisela. Groundskeeper. Gardens, graves, gutters. If it's outside and unpleasant, it's mine."
> She surveys the guests. "Stay on the paths. Leave the roses alone. And if a skeleton asks you for directions, send him to me. He's supposed to be working."

If asked about the ghost: "Never seen it pull a weed. Can't say I think much of it."

Move into the ghost's entrance

> Tobias turns back to his clock. Anton ducks through a service doorway with the guest list. Grisela shoulders her spade and heads toward the courtyard. For a moment, the great hall is quiet.

Pause, then begin the Phantom's entrance. All three have stepped away; do not spotlight Anton's departure.

2 • THE PHANTOM (PERFORM IT, ABOUT 2 MIN)

*Big wobbly ghost voice. Hold out one arm and point with your **LEFT** hand. ★*

A howl rolls down the staircase. A pale shape swoops over the banister: a cloaked figure in a ghostly mask, glowing green at the edges. It floats... a little low for a ghost, honestly. About kid height. ★

"FOOLS! I am the Ghost of Count Von Żarovich! My Crests are guarded by curses you cannot imagine! Leave my castle tonight... or JOIN me forever!"

It flings out its left hand and every door in the hall bangs open at once. A gust of cold air sweeps through, and with it a smell like rotten eggs. ★ Then the ghost is gone.

Let them react. If someone jokes about the smell, just smile.

3 • SPLITTING UP (READ ALOUD, ABOUT 1 MIN)

> The floor lurches. The great hall tilts like a ship, and the five open doors pull at you like magnets. You stagger apart in pairs: two by two, each pair tumbling through a different door, which slams shut behind you.

To Fred's player: "Fred, you know what to say." *(They'll say: "Let's split up, gang!")*

4 • THE RULES (OUT OF CHARACTER, ABOUT 1 MIN)

- "Each pair is in a different room of the castle, with your own helper GM. Every room has **one Crest** hidden in it."
- "Use your character sheets. Your powers are built for your room."
- "Your helper has envelopes with clues. If you get stuck, the castle will give you hints."
- "When you get your Crest, bring it **here, to the Grand Gate**, with anything else you found."
- "When you hear the **bell**, the castle is closing in. Finish up and come back to the Gate."
- "Be loud, have fun, and keep your hands off the envelopes until your helper says so."

5 • GO!

> "Your rooms await. Good luck... you'll need it."

- Uncover the stations. Helpers read each Player Introduction and start their clocks.
- **Start your 15-minute master timer.** At 15:00, **ring the bell**.
- As each pair arrives at the Gate, run the transition in `Finale_Script.md` (section 1).

THE GRAND GATE

House Rules of the Von Zarovich Estate

- Every room hides **one Crest**. Bring it **here**.
- Use your **character sheet**. Your powers were made for your room.
- Your **helper GM** holds the clue envelopes. Don't open them yourself!
- Bring **everything you find** to the Gate. Someone is not what they seem...
- When the **bell** tolls, the castle closes in. Return to the Gate!

All five Crests open the Gate. Good luck, meddlers.

Guest Invitations (Hand One to Each Player on Arrival; Print 3 Pages for 12)

YOU ARE INVITED

to the Masquerade of the Five Crests

Von Zarovich Estate · Halloween Night · Arrive at dusk

Five Crests. Five rooms. One Grand Gate. Whoever brings back all five claims the Count's fortune.

Costumes required. Courage optional.

Guest: _____

YOU ARE INVITED

to the Masquerade of the Five Crests

Von Zarovich Estate · Halloween Night · Arrive at dusk

Five Crests. Five rooms. One Grand Gate. Whoever brings back all five claims the Count's fortune.

Costumes required. Courage optional.

Guest: _____

YOU ARE INVITED

to the Masquerade of the Five Crests

Von Zarovich Estate · Halloween Night · Arrive at dusk

Five Crests. Five rooms. One Grand Gate. Whoever brings back all five claims the Count's fortune.

Costumes required. Courage optional.

Guest: _____

YOU ARE INVITED

to the Masquerade of the Five Crests

Von Zarovich Estate · Halloween Night · Arrive at dusk

Five Crests. Five rooms. One Grand Gate. Whoever brings back all five claims the Count's fortune.

Costumes required. Courage optional.

Guest: _____